Granting personhood to rivers

Rivers have a sacred importance in the cultural traditions of many Indigenous peoples. In Māori culture, the tupuna (ancestors) live on in the natural world, so communities have a duty to protect the landscape they inherit, especially its rivers.

The Whanganui tribes of New Zealand's North Island revere the river of the same name. They fought for—and in 2017, finally won—the right for the Whanganui River to be recognized as a legal entity, with rights, powers, duties, and liabilities. Two years later, the Yurok Tribal Council of Oregon, alarmed by years of low water levels and poor salmon numbers in the Klamath River, granted it personhood status.

Similarly, in 2021, the Innu First Nation in Canada awarded the same status to the Magpie River (Mutuhekau Shipu), which was under threat from a proposed hydroelectric project.

In 2024, the Huaynakana Kamatahuara Kana, a Kukama women's federation in Peru, succeeded in asserting the legal right to integrity and protection of the Marañón River, which was sacred to them. Outraged by more than 40 years of oil spills from a nearby pipeline, they argued that damaging the river threatened the health and livelihood of Indigenous villages on its banks, and also the river's "right to life."

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